



Aifven &lt;aifvennelson08@gmail.com&gt;

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**Re: your inquiry from webonary**

1 message

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**Christine Dreiheller** <christine\_dreiheller@sil.org>  
To: aifvennelson08@gmail.com

16 March 2026 at 11:51

Dear Aifven,

It's good to hear from you, and hear about your interest in your parents' language. From your website I gather that you are turning 18 this year! Wow, you started early!

You mention that for you as a software developer, your two main interests are to develop a digital translator for Rungus, and to develop an offline tool for the Rungus community, I assume for the Rungus dictionary.

Just to let you know, an offline Rungus dictionary app built from the same Flex database which is also published on webonary is already available as a mobile app for android. Check the Download tab on the webonary page or search for Rungus in PlayStore. This app, just like the webonary page, is regularly updated as the Flex database grows and is corrected. Just be warned, the most recent update of the app doesn't quite work as expected because the app builder software had a bug. That's why, right now, the front page of the app doesn't show much, but if you click on an entry, the content does show. This bug will be fixed in the next update.

As for the dictionary database itself, it is still under development. Despite the fact that we have over 12000 entries by now, many are incomplete or not very accurate yet, and there are many more entries and corrections needed before the dictionary is reasonably complete and reliable. Nonetheless we felt it makes sense to make it available for people to use even now, because producing a dictionary is a practically endless task and it would be too long a wait for everybody.

Your other goal, to develop a Rungus Digital Translator, sounds exciting and very ambitious. As a software developer who is aiming at a translation tool, you will be aware that to train any AI-based software on a language, you need enormous amounts of written data in that language as a resource. I'm not a software specialist, but a linguist, and as such I know that Rungus as a so-called minority language doesn't have the necessary enormous amounts of written texts available as have been used to build the LLMs available.

So it would be interesting to know about your plans to analyse the Rungus language data to extract the Rungus roots and affixes from it. As a linguist, I would have expected that you need to know the language you are planning to analyse to a certain degree in order to do that. But your website doesn't state Rungus as one of the languages you know. So that is an interesting question for me. Are you saying you want the software to analyse the Rungus grammar in order to find the roots and affixes and their meaning? If that could be achieved, that would of course be major progress.

So far, the only way to separate roots from affixes in Rungus is manual, and it is a complex task, as you note. Rungus has several dozen prefixes, a handful of suffixes and even a number of infixes, all of which can be combined with each other in countless different ways to create words which when translated into English or Malay become half a sentence. Rungus also has morphophonemic changes and vowel harmony which influence the shape of any particular affix or root. One way of dealing with this issue is by building a "hermit crab parser" for Rungus to run in Flex, but that is a major job I haven't had the time for yet. So if you had a solution for that, my team and I would certainly be interested.

Depending on how much Rungus you know, you will of course also realise that even apart from its words, Rungus sentence level grammar is also very complex. The order in which words appear, and the form they take, depends on the emphasis in the sentence, on the point you are trying to make, and there are particles, conjunctions and other bits and pieces which make a major contribution to the meaning of any sentence or passage. But perhaps when you say, you aim to build a digital translator, you just meant for words, not for whole texts?

So these are a few of the initial questions I would have. Since you are from Lokoton and/or Tinangol, you may want to drop by next time you are in Sabah (I don't live far from Tinangol) and we could talk about some of these things to see where it takes us. Just contact me ahead of time, to make sure I'm home.

Regards,  
Christine Dreiheller

On 12.03.2026 14:06, [www.webonary.org](http://www.webonary.org) wrote:

From: Aifven Vellvient Nelson <aifvennelson08@gmail.com>  
Subject: Inquiry regarding Rungus Webonary Data Access for Language Technology Project

Message Body:

To: Webonary Manager / Rungus Dictionary Project Team

Dear Webonary Team and Contributors,

My name is Aifven, and I am a developer interested in supporting the preservation and accessibility of the Rungus (Momogun) language. I am from Kudat and of Rungus descent! I have been following the excellent work done on the Rungus-Malay-English Dictionary hosted on Webonary.

I am currently planning the development of a Rungus Digital Translator. My goal is to create a tool that helps users especially the younger generation translate between Rungus, Malay, and English more efficiently.

To build an accurate engine, I am seeking access to the structured dictionary data. Specifically, I was wondering if it would be possible to obtain a copy of the LIFT (XML) file or a FLEEx backup of the Rungus database?

Having the data in a structured format would allow me to:

Implement a root-word lookup for complex Rungus affixes.

Ensure the orthography remains consistent with the standards set by your team.

Develop an API or offline tool for the Momogun community.

I am committed to respecting all copyright and attribution requirements for the original compilers (Traugott A. Forschner, Parasin Bongkol, Tracy Mocketong, Christine Dreiheller, and the rest of the team). I would be happy to discuss how this project can credit the Webonary contributors or even collaborate with your team to ensure the tool serves the community's needs.

Thank you for your time and for the vital work you do in preserving the Rungus heritage.

Best regards,

[Aifven Vellvient Nelson]

[<https://sites.google.com/view/aifvenvellvientnelson/achievements?authuser=0>]